

The Psychology of Protest: A Case Study of the 2024 Anti-Discrimination Movement in Bangladesh

Introduction:

Bangladesh and its people had been through a large scale alteration in the last few months; socially, politically and in many ways mentally. The July and August of 2024 has shown these people many new versions of themselves, opened their eyes and showed them what they can do, what they are capable of only if they are willing to act. A whole generation whose affection towards their motherland barely existed stood together resisting against the injustice of their then government. Following the passing of an injustice law, students asked for their rights and plea to reform the law only to receive a ruthless response from the government and civil defence. As the whole student body got together, a nationwide curfew was implemented but was unable to stop the protest. As the death toll was nowhere near declining, teachers, parents and more people from different backgrounds took part in the protest. This mass uprising ended up with the resignation of the 15 year long ruling party, making the beginning of a new era of the country.

But to gain this change “politically”, most of the people involved had to fight their own battle in their mind. Although different factors motivated people of different classes and professions, they all had to convince themselves to get on field, physically or with any type of support, despite all the rules and restrictions implemented by the government. In this case study, we would like to focus on one of such types; after students, they were the first to arrive on scene to protect and defend their kids, resisting the injustice: the university teachers.

With the assistance of psychological theories like the ‘Moral Courage Theory’ and the ‘Social Identity Theory’, we would explore how students’ safety and being part of the student-teacher body acted as the main motivation for university teachers to support them in the protest despite all the ‘official restrictions’. We would also try to look into a similar protest that took place in Hong Kong 5 years earlier.

Literature Review:

Moral courage is the ability to stand up for and practise what is considered ethical. It supports moral behaviour when faced with a dilemma, even if it means going against countervailing pressure to do otherwise (AACN, n.d.). This is when people decide to do 'what is right' without caring who they are standing against or what risks and backlashes it has to offer.

Social Identity Theory talks about when an individual's behaviour and mental built-up gets partly influenced by their membership in a social group or community, which creates a sense of belongingness that would make people act in favour of the group, especially when the group identity is threatened (McLeod, 2023).

Case Study Analysis:

To help with the analysis, we were able to interview a couple of department chairpersons from two different universities; one public and one private. Both having similar stands and ideology, we will try to look how their environment paved their decisions as they stood firm beside their students throughout the battle.

The protest started earlier on July 7th but escalated massively on the midnight of 15th July following a remark by the then prime minister. Later that day, the student wing of the ruling party attacked the general protesting students, inviting students all around the country to raise their voice. By 18th August, it was all warfare. Civil defence was open firing on students simply asking for their rights. At times, when students were getting shot, captured or arrested, teachers came in to support and protect.

One such remarkable incident occurred at BRAC University on 18th July. With 3 students shot dead by the police, several department heads, deans and chairpersons, and countless teachers came to the campus and returned, mostly on foot, with their students, safely under their guidance. I was fortunate to be able to talk to one of them. Another interviewee was a department chairperson of the Dhaka University.

Evidence of Moral Courage was all over our conversations. When asked what encouraged them to support their students, both had similar answers which reflected that it was their

immediate response to ensure the students safety. As answered by one of them, “A strong sense of justice and ethics compelled me to stand with the students, even at personal risk, because the cause they represented was fair, logical, and morally urgent.” The statement reflects how strongly moral courage acted behind the ethical instead of logical reasoning. Explaining what personal values gave them the strength, answers turned out to be like, “The belief in doing what’s right, upholding truth, and challenging injustice outweigh the dangers involved, made me show solidarity.” Considering private (mention-able BracU) and public university, the level of restriction from the authority differed at a very massive scale. Still, teachers from all sides came in to support. Some had the freedom to be open about it, some had to stay low to not capture the administration's eye. And this fear or anxiety about the repercussions were distinct in their answers with one stating, “Yes, I had serious fear about the possible consequences of my actions as I am a part of the administration at a Public University.” It was her courage that did not let her stop. The other chairperson claimed, “I never thought about this in that way. At that moment, it was all about doing what was right.” However, the ‘system’ remained common for all and they all had to turn their back on the government’s restriction to save their students and do what was right. This was well put in this response, “We were quiet for 15 years, adjusting to the system, but when the killing of our students started, the change in attitude was more like we need to go, regardless of what happens to us.”

Now focusing on the Social Identity Theory, we will try to talk more about how being part of the university pushed them instead of their individual judgement. Both chairpersons were clear to state that their stands would have been unchanged regardless of their position, “As a department chair, my position likely amplified my sense of responsibility to support the students, as I was seen as both a leader and advocate within the academic community. The role provided a platform to influence and protect the students more effectively. However, my core principles of justice and student welfare would have remained unchanged, and I would have likely supported them regardless of my title, though perhaps with less authority or direct impact.” This teacher-student relation was further put to test as they talked about themselves being open to approach by all students at any need, and having a mutual respect and trust among themselves. “I strive to create a supportive and inclusive environment where they feel heard and valued, both academically and personally. It’s important to me that they see me not only as an authority figure but as someone who genuinely cares about their growth, well-being, and success. This connection is rooted in mentorship, empathy, and a shared

commitment to learning and progress.” This strength in relation, had likely played a massive role in making the teacher form a bond or alliance and wall of protection for their students. Yes, they had to maintain their loyalty towards their job but before being part of the institution’s administration, they managed to stay the teacher to their students and fight for them. And in a bigger picture, both agreed that the supportive actions taken for the students was equally an expression of solidarity with their group of fellow teachers.

We can see similar accounts from the 2019-2020 Hong Kong protest.

Showing Moral Courage, several teachers participated directly in the anti-government protests (Ives et al., 2020), risking their safety; many ended up becoming symbolic figures of resistance by helping students organise protests or mediate with authorities (Branigan et al., 2020). Lai-LaGrotteria (2021) covered that, many teachers advised students on their legal safety or participated quietly in the protests by donating food and supplies to the frontline despite the fact that this supporting act might bring unwanted attention or legal scrutiny.

Showing Social Identity, the report by Branigan et al. (2020) shows the long history of university-led activism in Hong Kong showed how teachers and students often saw themselves as part of the same struggle for democracy. Lai-LaGrotteria (2021) talked about how the teachers’ social identity as part of the pro-democracy movement or as members of Hong Kong’s education system influenced their actions to take part directly or indirectly in the protest. Shek (2020) found out how some teachers viewed themselves as protectors of academic freedom and democratic values. This sense of shared identity with students, who were fighting for these same principles, made it easier for them to support the protests.

Discussion:

In this study, we focused on how teachers played an important role to ensure that the protest kept going and the protesters remained safe. In many cases, students need to stay far from their home to study in university and their teachers are like their guardians and fortunately, they did not turn their back on us. There are definitely many more psychological aspects to analyse these situations from but we tried our best to uphold the drive of moral courage and social identity, emphasising how their ethics and closeness made them support the students; not as a part of their duty rather their sense of justice and care towards the students. We also discussed some similarities with the protest in Hong Kong. In both cases, educators were

motivated by their deep connection to the academic community, both teachers and students, underscoring the role of group identity and ethical principles in fueling collective action against injustice.

Conclusion:

The involvement of the teachers in both the protests discussed here shows how teachers need to be biased, if needed, to support their students. It sends a clear message that there is no neutral, silent, ground when one of your own is at danger. We must do what is right; what we personally think is right and what is collectively right. Amidst these, as Bangladesh walks upon its starting days in the new era, the same bonding that brought the freedom must be kept to preserve it. Drastic change in mentality might end up making all the sacrifices of no use. The educated and the educators have a long way to lead their motherland to peace.

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